1. To understand the most important characteristics of a society, one must study its major cities. ways

Where do we start when we want to learn about a new society？ For the speaker, the answer seems very clear: we should look at its major cities. While the cities shed light on many important aspects of a society, I argue that the lesser- known areas are still not to be overlooked.

For starters, it would be silly to understate the value of major cities in displaying important traits of a society. Just look at New York. When the American economy was down, New York was the first to feel the chill: bankrupted businesses, jobless people, and empty stores. New York is not just the financial center of America; it is also its cultural center. Being labeled as one of the most diverse countries in the world, America embraces people of all ethnicities and colors in its society, as can also be vividly displayed on New York's streets. New York does not care where you're from. You can be American, Hungarian, Thai, Chinese, Ethiopian, or Nigerian, but you can still be a New Yorker.

However, it is exactly because big cities catch the spotlight that they tend to display only the things under the spotlight. When one thinks about American culture, one easily relates to Hollywood images and Billboard hotlists. These belong to contemporary pop culture. But the American countryside has also had its share of contribution: country music. Maybe one would say that we still get to see country music performances in big cities. Yes, you see country music stars like Blake Shelton and Keith Urban, who probably never had a day of work in the barn. The authentic country music belongs to the real experiences of real working countrymen; it is more than just a highly commercialized pattern of notes or a meaningless juxtaposition of words like "cold beer, dirt road, or pickup truck" that supposedly symbolize country life.

Likewise, city dwellers often tend to hold different cultural values from country residents. If you go to New York, you may be under the illusion that the whole of America embraces the values of diversity and liberalism. You would be oblivious to the fact that there is a vast part of America that is conservative and holds many traditional values. This is not to judge which value is preferable; rather, I am here to argue that neither large cities like New York nor minor places can represent what American people believe in. To try to find one place that displays what is innately heterogeneous is in itself, a futile practice to begin with.

Overall, understanding a society takes more effort than just looking at these major cities. While this is an important step, it is just one step among many before gathering enough information about that society.

3. Scandals are useful because they focus our attention on problems in ways that no speaker or reformer ever could.
challenge your position.

The prompt claims that scandals, by focusing our attention on important issues, are useful tools for modern society. I absolutely agree that our attention is often drawn to all the dark secrets revealed by the powerful and omnipresent mass media, but I remain skeptical of the alleged contributions these scandals bring to our world.

I don't think many people can deny the power of an eye- catching scandal. When Tiger Woods was reported to have multiple mistresses, the news went viral. Or when Bill Cosby's sexual assault was revealed, he became the topic of discussion everywhere. Or the very recent scandal of American college enrollment— I was reading it just a few hours ago on my cellphone. The public loves scandals, and the media loves giving them out. Especially given the development of social networks, scandals spread much faster than ever, so they reach a much wider audience than before.

But are these scandals really useful？ How can we right the wrong, when the wrong is unknown, one might argue. Supposedly, scandals help reveal otherwise hidden injustices in the world, and this should be at least the first step towards bettering the society. As far as I can remember, whenever a corrupt official has been discovered, the government temporarily initiates an anti-corruption process that reduces malfeasance within the system. Temporary salvation, that's the best we can get.

Turning on our cellphones every day, chances are we will see a new scandal, whether it's an affair, corruption, rape, or drug deal. Scandals are so common that modern people easily become oblivious. Yes, scandals still catch attention, but for no more than a couple of days. The crowd gets furious for 48 hours, and then they become excited about some other stuff. If you're a celebrity worrying about your secret affair being released, your best chance is to sleep through the night, and tomorrow is going to be a better day for you, well, unless you want the exposure. No problems are going to be solved whatsoever.

What's worse is that the media actually fabricates stories to create scandals, so much so that it's hard to distinguish what's important and what's not. People become indulgent in personal attacks, and forget about the real issues. Just recall the latest presidential election. What a joke！ Liberal and conservative media took turns picking on the opponents' character flaws, while the real issues were being evaded. Wait, what were the real issues? I only recall Clinton's email problems and Trump's sex and tax and Russian scandals. Wow! There were a lot of them. I even started to suspect that the two sides were collaborating to entertain me with these sensational stories so that I wouldn't question the fundamental injustice of our society.

I think my stance is quite clear. I myself am often drawn to scandals, so I must congratulate the media for successfully manipulating my attention. But I think they are the virus of modern society.

11. Universities should require every student to take a variety of courses outside the student's field of study.
challenge your position.

Almost every university in the modern education system requires students to take courses beyond their own major fields of study. This pervasive phenomenon itself should suggest, if not guarantee, that there are good reasons for learning additional subjects. In this essay, I shall try to illuminate the rationale behind it.

For starters, today's academic circle has seen a growing connection between what used to be relatively separate fields of study. The arts heavily rely on technology: businesses are built on mathematical models; philosophy makes use of advances in neurological study: even the field of humanities is witnessing the rise of “digital humanities", branch that incorporates statistical analysis. Simply put, whatever field one is in, that field is going to depend more or less on the advance of other related disciplines, so its practitioners had better build a wider repertoire to be fully prepared.

Second, life is a long journey with many unexpected twists and turns. In college, it is just impossible to imagine all the unpredictability lying ahead. What one currently studies may not necessarily be their eventual career path. Tools that seem immediately irrelevant may end up becoming her bread and butter. It is just so common today that a student graduates from school and never does any related to her undergrad major ever again. Learning other courses provides a student with new inspirations that may completely change her future.

However, some people may argue that there will be students who have already decided for sure what they would want to do later in their lives, so learning anything else would be a waste of their time. I cannot deny that some students are very certain and specific about their passion, and they-would normally intend to pursue that path as much as possible and become the best in the field. Yet the higher one climbs in a field, the more weapons he/she needs from elsewhere. A regular accountant needs just accounting skills; but a business leader needs to know about the product, management, law, technology, and many more. A reporter knows how to write story: but the head editor of a news agency would have to understand politics, literature, marketing, and beyond.

Some may argue that taking additional courses should be discretionary rather than mandatory. However, college students are generally young adults who have barely learned how to live independently and make responsible decisions. Often, giving them the choice not to challenge themselves is tantamount to having them not challenge themselves. If learning outside knowledge is anywhere as important as I said earlier then the merits deserve a little sacrifice on students' freedom of choice. They will benefit later on by having more options in their lives.

Overall, I believe that it is wise for students to take on classes outside their majors. For this to happen, they should be required to do so.

18. Some people believe that college students should consider only their own talents and interests when choosing a field of study. 0thers believe that college students should base their choices of a field of study on the availability of jobs in that field.

both of the views

How should a student determine what major he/she will enter, by job prospect or by his/her talent and interest? Obviously, this is just one of the many questions about life choices that just do not have a single undebatable answer. It is really a matter that is completely up to one's self-understanding.

Not everyone graduating from high school knows who he/she really is. Take the Chinese high school education system for example. Everyone here takes a similar set of curriculum. If you focus on science and technology, you're required to take Chinese, math, English, physics, chemistry and biology: or if you focus on the humanities, you will have taken Chinese, math, English, politics, history and geography. Most students are, therefore, not actually aware of other possibilities that could one day influence their career. In fact, a lot of skills that could later become important assets in a profession, for example, communication skills, the ability to handle pressure, and physical strength, cannot be reflected at this stage. Consequently, if student is not exceptional in any of these fields, chances are high that he/she knows about neither his/her own passion nor his/her natural gift. What is his/her best bet for a choice of major then? I do believe basing the decision on job availability is the rational thing to do. Today, if you pick computer science, for example, even if you only attend a second-tier college and you get an average GPA of C+, you are still going to be popular on the job market. Many Internet startups are in desperate need of coders, so these professionals get much higher pay than fresh graduates from most other majors. Yes, the student may not enjoy his/her job, but let's be realistic. He/she will have enough money, and he/she can do fun things after work.

But there are always exceptions. If you go to one of the best colleges in China, say Peking University, you will see a number of brilliant young people who know very early on who they are and what they are going to do. You will see 16-year old freshman students who finish college physics curriculum before entering college, and are already way of others doing research on quantum physics and string theory. You will also see young fiction writers who have already published a few best-selling novels in their freshman year and sign autographs for their fans. If someone is going to tell them that there are few available spots for top physicists or that professional writing isn't a stable job, they will probably tell the person to mind his/her own business. It's true. Even if these career paths are much narrower for most people, it's still a bright open path for the ones with extraordinary talent and unlimited drive.

Overall, don't think there should be a uniform decision for everyone. For those who show unmatched gifts and passions, they should just not care about job availability. For others, they probably need to put their foot down and be realistic.

28. Teachers' salaries should be based on their students' academic performance.
challenge your position

I think it is a great idea that teachers' salaries be determined by their students' academic performance. This policy would boost teachers' devotion to their teaching, and that would be reflected in their students' success.
To begin with, it feels quite redundant to have to explain the benefit of this policy. To get a clear sight, we need look no further than what happens in the absence of this policy is absent. In many public schools in China, teachers are paid according to seniority. Consequent, we see so many 50-year-old experienced teachers whose expertise is completely outdated. Their students would be better off looking for resources online than consulting these senior teachers. There are also schools where teachers are paid based on their diplomas. However, PhD does not guarantee that one knows how to teach. So many people who are great at research are poor at verbal communication, and thus totally inadequate at being a good teacher. In contrast, rewarding a teacher based on how his/her students perform is directly aimed at benefiting students. At least teachers would have the incentive to work harder, and the ones that fail to help students would gradually be sifted out.

Now, what are the possible counter point? Perhaps one may say that the measure could cause teachers to push students too hard, and then they would no longer feel the joy of learning Well, doesn't this argument serve my point of view? If a teacher pushes students too hard and deprives his/her students of the joy of learning, his/her students will not progress or perform well, and then he/she will not be paid well. This policy in the long run will push teachers to work smarter, not just harder. It is the teachers who know how to excite students while teaching knowledge that will end up earning the most.

Some may also argue that academic performance is not all that is valuable in learning. Academic performance apparently only reflects a student's intellectual strength, but what about her mental and moral growth do believe that modern standardized exams are one dimensional-they just evaluate students' intellects while ignoring all other aspects. However, while the school is responsible in some degree for students' overall growth, each individual teacher is not. A math teacher teaches math, and that is his/her job description. If he/ she helps his/her whole class progress in math, then he/she deserves his/her pay, end of discussion. So if there was a teacher or a group of mentors responsible for the students' moral or mental growth, then some other performance evaluation test could be designed that fit that aim. But when it comes to academic disciplines, we don't have many valid reasons to make a clear case complex.

To sum up, while paying a teacher based on students' performance may sound cruel and rigid, it is still better than all the other measures that have been tried. When it comes to education, there is no lack of idealists. Teaching is a modern job, and the job is to improve students' academic performance. So when the most direct evaluation criterion is readily available, I see little reason to seek detour.

47.Claim: We can usually learn much more from people whose views we share than from those whose views contradict our own.

Reason: Disagreement can cause stress and inhibit learning.

claim and the reason

The prompt claims that, because disagreement causes stress and inhibits learning, we learn more from people who share ideas with us than from those whose ideas conflict with our own. In general, I do believe that it is our human nature to prefer to listen to advice and opinions from those we feel that we have much in common with, but also believe that when we learn to control our emotional sides, we can still manage to gain from differences.

What I take the prompt to mean is that when we share many ideas with a person already, we are more inclined to learn from that person. From psychological point of view, when we are too different from someone, we generally don't even want to talk to that person, let alone learn from him/her. For example, when I was a student, I remember not liking my math teacher because he really enjoyed talking about politics and thought that all of us needed to hold strong political positions. Politics was not a topic that captured my attention, ever, so his value pushed me away from his math class. I know now that I should have separated his political views from his academic ability, because that could have benefited me better, but as a high schooler, I could hardly be so rational, and neither were many of my fellow classmates. When we felt that we couldn't connect with the teacher, we simply stopped learning. Therefore, I do agree that too much disagreement is stressful to learners, especially immature ones.

However, as people grow and mature mentally, particularly if they become critical adults, they are more likely to set aside differences between people and appreciate inspiring ideas. Yes, it is still true that when someone with completely different values from mine argues with me, feel an initial repulsion. However, afterwards, can sit back and reflect on the debate and often feel inspired. Even when I read a book about someone don't feel connected to, I can appreciate their innovative ideas. For example, when I read the biography of Steve Jobs, I didn't like a lot of things about him. I shared none of his temper, his showmanship, or a lot of his philosophies, but still I thought he was a great entrepreneur because he believed in "creating demands" rather than "catering to demands". I even tried to apply that idea to my own field, and found it quite helpful.

So overall, I do believe that disagreement can cause psychological distance between people, and for the less reflective ones, learning is inhibited. But for intellectually mature ones, they can more or less overcome that psychological barrier and try to learn something whether it is from people holding similar ideas or from those with different ones.

48. Government officials should rely on their own judgment rather than unquestioningly carry out the will of the people they serve.

circumstances

It is not easy to be a government official. You are constantly judged by the people you serve, and you never seem to satisfy everybody's needs. In fact, you never will, so it is important to have your own judgment on important issues. That said, one should not go to the other extreme of completely ignoring people's opinions. In fact, a government official should always form his/her own judgment but that judgment should be based on sufficient research of relevant information and a comprehensive consideration of people's needs.

For starters, an official simply cannot indiscriminately listen to people's will, because the term "people's will" assumes, unwarrantedly, the homogeneity of people's opinions when in reality, society is always a mixture of conflicting interests, all of which belong to people. Say the government wants to build a big dam. Areas that suffer from lack of electricity would applaud the decision, but those living close to where the dam is going to be constructed would hate the idea because the project would require their relocation. There is never going to be a single solution that makes everyone happy. It is ultimately the official's judgment that balances the interests of different groups. However, the balance would mean that he/she has taken into consideration the needs of everyone involved, because he/she would probably approve the construction but at the same time offer those nearby residents a huge relocation fee.

It is also easy to picture a scenario where an urgent decision has to be made, say, to send out rescue teams after an earthquake or a tsunami. How many people should be sent? How much material should be provided? How should the materials be shipped? You cannot wait for the people to give an answer, because they don't have all the information available. You can only listen to the opinion of experts on disasters; you probably also need to draw a priority list of what's most important to save and what's next. However, this isn't equal to neglecting people's will. What you do in these situations is serve your people's best interest.

Regarding projects aiming to boost a nation's long-term potential, an official often has to temporarily leave aside people's wills, because the public tends to be short-sighted. If you initiate survey among people on what they think the government should do, generally they would prefer the government to fight street crimes, reduce commodity prices, create more jobs, or improve health care. On the contrary, few would recommend space exploration, environment protection, or espionage. These issues are less pressing, from most peoples' perspectives. However, for a large nation, funding on these aspects is important to secure the nation's' long-term- competitiveness. If the public doesn’t see it, the government should.

But I would never go so far as to say the government should be blind to people's will. At least, its decisions need to be transparent to its people. The transparency is necessary so that the government's power will not go unchecked. Corruption, and even dictatorship often start with the pretext that the government alone can decide what's best for its people. In conclusion, the government is more informed on lot of issues than its people, so it should never blindly obey its people's will. However, its decisions should always be aimed at benefiting people's needs, both long-term and short-term.

49. Young people should be encouraged to pursue long-term, realistic goals rather than seek immediate fame and recognition.

circumstance

Ask any teacher from a formal education system how they think the desire for fame works for children, and chances are high that they will comment negatively. It is our tradition to value long-term hard work over the pursuit of overnight fame. However, with the explosion of information, today's world has changed, for better or for worse, so I do believe that a wholesale rejection of fame seeking has become an outdated perspective. In fact, what kind of goals one should set really depends on the specific industry he/she is in.

For starters, the reason why old people often advise young people to set a long-term, realistic target is that the desire for immediate success generally leads people to focus on what's on the surface. People may look for shortcuts without trying to improve their critical skills. This is indeed a big problem if you are in a field where expertise and experiences play a crucial part. For example, if you aim to become a leading scientist, it is quite unlikely, if possible at all, to gain fame at a relatively young age. You will have to work in labs for years and accumulate an understanding of your field; also, it takes years to climb the academic ladder and to become eligible to lead a team of researchers. The goal of becoming a well-established scientist almost always takes decades to achieve.

But the stark contrast can easily be envisioned. In show business, everyone seeks immeidate recognition. If you don't get recognized, your career is probably going to be a dead end. Look at all those winners from American ldol or America's Next Top Model. Don't tell me that they go onto the show to achieve their long-term, realistic goals. They often say that they've dreamed years and worked so hard, and that they would do whatever it takes to succeed. No, they didn't work that hard, at least nothing compared to what one has to do to become a Stephen Hawking or a Roger Federer. See all those fashion bloggers who are followed by millions of fans worldwide. It doesn't take them decades of hard work to succeed. What it takes is a beautiful face and the ability to publicize. Should I criticize their life choices? I am not even qualified to judge. They have money, and they have influence. They define success in the contemporary world.

I might sound a little cynical. In fact, I am not. Not all fields are like research or entertainment. Most are in the middle, where you need a little of both. Children that want to pursue a career in the business world would be better advised to work hard for a long-term career plan but at the same time learn to promote a better image The success of Apple is the best illustration. It takes years for its creators to keep updating their products to new heights: we all know how much Apple revolutionizes our conception of IT products. On the other hand, Steve Jobs' showmanship played an equally crucial role in selling Apple's idea to hundreds of millions of users worldwide. In this age, you need a catchy image to attract customers and investors; but in the long run, a fascinating business concept needs to be backed up by truly exceptional products. This balance indeed reflects the two kinds of goals a future business leader needs to set.

Overall, our modern world is a diverse space with different philosophies. One should not believe that successful people are all the same. Instead, for young people to succeed, what they really need is to know who they are and what they want. These understandings are essential when they set goals for their future.

53. In order for any work of art-for example, a film, a novel, a poem, or a song-to have merit, it must be understandable to most people.

ways

The prompt holds that the only valuable works of art are those that are understandable to most people. To me, this statement is simply overly assertive: there are many art pieces that are perfectly valuable while not accessible to many outsiders. As long as an artwork delivers its message to the intended audience, it has its merit.

For starters, of course one can criticize a pop artwork if it is opaque to the majority. That is because popular arts are supposed to entertain the general audience. Therefore, if Taylor Swift writes a song that doesn't sell, then one may be warranted to label that song as failure. Indeed, when pop artists create an item that ends up being a market disaster, they often make a lame excuse saying that they are doing real art that most people just don't have the elevated taste to appreciate. This excuse is not acceptable because if you really want to make an authentic art piece that doesn't cater to the crowd, you probably shouldn't be doing pop art at all

However, the same criticism would not be legitimate if it aims at other art genres, those that in the very beginning try to distance themselves from most people's tastes. Take heavy metal music for example. Yes, it is loud and full of screams. Yes, I personally find it annoying. However, understand why my young nephew likes it, because that kind of rebellious message speaks to people at his stage of life. The music represents his attempt to fight against the mainstream, and helps him express his passion. The street artists that spray graffiti are doing something similar. For those of us who would like things to be in neat order, the vibrant paint on street walls can be invasive, but they address the mentality of many young people who want to challenge the status quo.

In fact, the arts are supposed to be genuine; they should be the honest display of one's heart and soul. A pop song can have the lyric "girl your face is just so fine that I cannot stop thinking about it even for one sec" and is understandable to even kindergarten kids, but it means nothing because the singer really doesn't believe it at all and he is just using this choreographed trash to make money. True arts are honest. If you write a love song that only your lover appreciates, it serves your purpose. Sometimes you draw a random pattern just to reflect your darkest hours, it means something, because you understand it. Later on, when you, the only audience, look at it and find strength from that darkest moment, that piece has served its meaning.

Overall, the value of art can rarely, if ever, be evaluated by the number of people that can appreciate it. The merit of an art work is never objective and never should be.

55. The main benefit of the study of history is to dispel the illusion that people living now are significantly different from people who lived in earlier times.
ways

From the author's perspective, the major benefit of studying history is to reveal that people living in different ages do not differ drastically from each other. As we examine different aspects of human life throughout history, we shall see that while no significant changes have taken place regarding human nature, both our material life and our social values have evolved long way from the past. In fact, knowing about both these similarities and these differences can be very helpful in our lives. Therefore, I believe that the speaker's view is too general.

To begin with, I do concede that there is something eternal with humanity, its virtue and its vices. Throughout history, we've celebrated individuals that display honesty, integrity and altruism; on the other hand, we've also constantly witnessed the waging of wars, a manifestation of the greed that is forever within our human race. As long as we are humans, we will feel love, compassion and courage, but we will also be bound by fear, jealousy and lust.

However, there is no reason to deny that even the most cursory understanding of history would suffice to reveal the enormous progress our intellect has achieved. From the very earliest domestication of cereal to the very modern genetic modification, from the invention of the wheel to the manipulation of international space stations, or from the crudest hieroglyphic carvings to the most sophisticated computer algorithms, every step of technological development marks a giant leap in our mental power. If any of our ancestors could witness the modern world, he would be shocked by how much his kind have accomplished.

At the same time, every history textbook would portray an evolving journey of our cultural values. Thousands of years ago, women were by default considered the inferior gender whose lives were expected to be confined domestically; they would never expect that one day a woman could stand on the highest podium of modern country, making her voice heard by each one of her people. Likewise, we can all recall the time when black people were treated like animals today, race is widely believed to be irrelevant to the excellence of an individual, as long as he or she is given equal opportunity. Similar examples are aplenty: what we used to believe about religion, sexual orientation, mental illnesses, and marriage are all under pressure of shift, hopefully for the better.

All in all, I think the author fails to take sufficient consideration of different aspects of human life. While history does display certain commonalities within humanity, it also sheds light on a drastic contrast between us and our ancestors.

64. Some people believe that society should try to save every plant and animal species, despite the expense to humans in effort, time, and financial well-being. Others believe that society need not make extraordinary efforts, especially at a great cost in money and jobs, to save endangered species.
both of the views presented

Should our society spend enormous amounts of money and human resources saving endangered species? Well, this is clearly another one of those issues that try to strike a balance between our long-term benefits and our immediate needs. This time I vote for the long-term benefits and believe that it is our obligation to save other species, because that will eventually save us.

To begin with, the main thing at stake is biodiversity. Diversity is important because it protects the stability of our ecosystem. When vital part of the food chain is eliminated, it can cause a ripple effect that affects many other elements in the cycle. For example, the endangerment of certain frog species would mean that pests have fewer predators than before, so eventually it is human agriculture and forestry that will suffer. Also, wildlife preservation, besides its direct ecological value, is significant for academic research. Biology, chemistry, medicine and many other areas benefit from the persistence of diverse range of species. It helps us better understand the evolutionary relationships of species and the biological functions of chemicals. Simply put, we don't need to sound altruistic when we save other species; we are simply doing it for our best interest.

However, there are too many short-sight critics who believe that environmental protection is a drain on our finance. They argue that protecting wildlife means excessive spending of money and human resources that could and should be used on other, more pressing issues. There are clear problems with this argument. In fact, the statement that wildlife protection demands extraordinary resources is simply not true. It is never as financially demanding as many other causes that we engage in so extravagantly, say space exploration and military upgrades. In fact, often what we need to do is simply not pollute. Others may argue that stopping pollution is itself an excessive cost, because it would entail that we stop building plants in certain resourceful areas. However, a well-preserved environment is itself a money-maker it boosts tourism. Also, stopping pollution doesn't necessarily stop all factory building; it just requires the factories to install facilities that minimize the amount of harmful waste directly released into the natural environment.

Overall, our politicians should be wise enough to look beyond immediate financial interests. We will almost certainly regret doing less than we need to. Our overall benefit requires harmony between us and nature.

65. Some people believe that the purpose of education is to free the mind and the spirit. Others believe that formal education tends to restrain our minds and spirits rather than set them free. both of the views

The prompt makes it seem as if the two statements are contradictory, while in fact the first states the purpose of education whereas the latter is about the reality of formal education. They are not necessarily inimical propositions. Nonetheless, I am inclined to disagree with the former and to endorse the latter.

From a personal perspective, it is enticing to think that we go to school to free our minds and spirits. Of course, I want to be inspired to think outside the box. However, from a social perspective, that is totally not the reason why a nation supports an entire education system. Reality says that the nation needs to produce enough work forces to maintain its operation. Two hundred years ago, a society needed plentiful workers and farmers. Today, as machinery gradually replaces menial labor, our social needs are somewhat elevated; we duplicate seemingly "fancier" jobs like auditors, lawyers, doctors, or coders in short, higher paid and more skillful workers. Still, medical schools' most urgent job is not to cultivate creative doctors to renovate the whole medical system; its pressing need is to fill the work force with sufficient graduates who can practice the routines of treating patients, and it has little to do with freeing minds or spirits. The same holds for law schools and many others. We as individuals would like to think that as we go to law schools, we are superior to our forefathers who had to tread in farmland At best, we appear superior.

With that purpose of education clarified it becomes inevitable that formal education eventually restrains people's minds. Our math class trains us to repeatedly solve problems fast and accurately; our language class teaches us to write sentences formally, free from grammatical errors, like what I'm doing now. In college and graduate schools, problems become tougher and more sophisticated but still everything is done in a mechanical way and evaluated against stringent rules.

Doesn't our society need innovators who defy all the traditions? Yes, it does, and that's exactly how it progresses. However, these individuals are neither the purpose nor the end result of formal education. Formal education does not worry about suppressing their rebellious nature, because it cannot be suppressed. They were born with the genes to transgress and are little confined by the rules. Charles Darwin, Steve Jobs, to name a few, are exactly the kinds I'm referring to.

Overall, I don't think that education aims to free; the education system is just a modern factory that seeks to mass produce replaceable parts, and mostly ends up with those. Creative geniuses? They are the byproducts.

71. In this age of intensive media coverage it is no longer possible for a society to regard any living man or woman as a hero.
ways

The prompt suggests that as a result of pervasive media scrutiny, there is no common hero in our modern society. I definitely agree that the media has directly and indirectly undermined heroic images, and here is why.

The first factor is sensationalism. Modern media are controlled by money-seeking corporations, and to boost sales, there is nothing better than something eye-catching. Nothing grasps viewers' attention better than a good scandal of a well-celebrated public figure. From Bill Clinton to Michael Jackson, from Tiger Woods to Steve Jobs, no one is immune to paparazzi. From sexual scandals to family crisis, from personality flaws to unethical behaviors, every aspect of these famous people's lives is scrutinized to the maximum. No one is perfect, so under the microscope of modern media, the "perfect" heroic image is bound to collapse. In this way, the media gossip often directly tarnishes celebrities' reputations.

However, one may argue that those I listed above are not real heroes in the traditional sense. Real heroes are not politicians, athletes, or showmen. What these people do is exceptional, but still driven by personal interest. Real heroes sacrifice their own benefit for the greater good. These are fire fighters, soldiers, and the otherwise obscure names who save other people without concern for themselves. We would never see media say one bad word about these people. Isn't there consensus regarding these heroic behaviors?

I agree that these are truly honorable people who have done truly honorable deeds. But still, not everyone agrees in this modern society. This somewhat unfortunate result is also related to media. With the rapid spread of information, today's society has become much more diverse, with multiple values coexisting. It is no longer our forefather's time, when people celebrated the same virtues. I personally admire firefighters, but you still see Internet comments saying that they are getting paid to do what they do. I think soldiers are extraordinarily courageous, but pacifists still counter that everyone involved in war is sinful. I was moved to tears when saw on the news that a middle-age man jumped into icy waters to save two strangers but was too exhausted in the end to save himself. But others argue that the media should not promote this value, because one needs to be responsible for himself/herself first, so as to be responsible for others. Yes, I think many such comments are completely insane and inhumane, but cannot be blind to their existence.

Eventually, I have to concede that we cannot expect unanimity in this modern world. Thanks to the media, we have heroes no more.

82. Claim: Nations should suspend government funding for the arts when significant numbers of their citizens are hungry or unemployed.

Reason: It is inappropriate-and, perhaps, even cruel-to use public resources to fund the arts when people's basic needs are not being met.

claim and the reason

The speaker concludes that the government should suspend funding for the arts when the country suffers from hunger and unemployment, because it seems unjust to waste resources on less pressing needs when basic ones are not secured. As much as I agree that the needs for food and jobs clearly outweigh artistic demands, this reason alone does not warrant a rash decision to completely stop funding the arts.

Let me first concede that people's basic needs should always be a nation's' priority. When my family was poor, my mom and dad would spend their entire time working multiple shifts; at the same time, there were no paintings, movies, music or other kinds of recreation in our lives. Simply put, when survival was on the line, we would not have the luxury to even think about satisfying our desires for artistic appreciation, if we still had any left.

However, on a societal scale, much more debatable is whether the government should simply neglect the development of the arts just for the sake of combating starvation and unemployment. Off the top of my head is the counterargument that the arts and economy are no longer dichotomous. A significant portion of the population in modern society makes their living on the arts or related businesses. The number of musicians, painters and performers is growing; meanwhile, skyscrapers erected, gardens built, movies filmed, blogs posted, headlines written, photos shot, clothes produced, and furniture made all have roles involving the crafts of artists. Stopping funding for the arts would mean that many are facing life-struggling moments.

In addition, the arts are uplifting, especially in cases of crises. When morale is low in the society, people need cheerful songs and movies to keep their hopes up. Many are the incidences when downhearted people become encouraged and empowered by messages delivered in inspiring performances.

Finally, suspending funding for the arts will simply not help with other, more pressing issues. Every powerful nation, the U. S., China, Japan, the U. K., and Germany, has starving or jobless people. None of them use all of their resources in solving unemployment. Why? The cause of these problems is not a simple lack of resources, but also whether resources are being used efficiently and fairly. If every country funds the arts only after its last jobless person gets hired, we may not be able to see that day come.

Overall, while the incentive behind the speaker's suggestion is humane and laudable, the suggestion itself is impetuous and unwarranted. The arts are too valuable an asset to neglect in today's world, and to ultimately alleviate a nation's pressing problems, we would have to look further for solutions much less short-sighted.

93. People's behavior is largely determined by forces not of their own making.
challenge

Do we make the call for our own actions? Can we be truly responsible for what we do? These are the questions that have been haunting western philosophers for centuries, who sought an answer to the metaphysical question of free will. Of course, I am no Emanuel Kant, but believe that the instinct to attribute one's own mistakes to other people or to society is typical of the weak-minded. Simply put, while we are certainly influenced by factors beyond our own control, ultimately we still decide most of what we do, if not all.

We undergo scenarios like the following all the time. Janice, a fictional character I just made up, is choosing her major, and she is struggling between two options, philosophy or business. She loves philosophy: she is constantly inspired by the great thinkers in history and would like to be on path seeking the meaning of her life. On the other hand, she is a little bit insecure about her job prospects after graduation. After all, going to business school seems to be the better choice if she wants a lucrative career. Her parents strongly encourage her to become a leading entrepreneur, because they have just read Sandberg's Lean in, and totally believe that women should seize their opportunities in the modern business world. Let's suppose that Janice ends up in business school. Is it any less her choice just because of her parents' persuasion? I highly doubt so, because while they did give her the extra little push, the motive was hers. Had she been fully committed to the other option, the story would have ended totally differently. We encounter similar choices almost constantly. Even if we are influenced by family and friends, society and history, ultimately, we must have the motives already in ourselves to make up our minds. In this way, we cannot say that we are determined by factors beyond our control.

Of course, some people may point to many cases in which the agent does seem dominated by outside forces, for example, a gay kid born in the Deep South in a religious family holding traditional views. The pressure on him might be so overwhelming that he does appear to have no alternative options other than to stay in the closet. Does he really? The truth is, many people have experienced similar ordeals. While a lot of them made similar moves, there are always those few who do otherwise. Threatened at gunpoint, most cave, but some fight back. Born in bad neighborhood, many end up in gang fights or selling drugs, but some seize opportunities, and thrive. Therefore, I believe that, to attribute what we do completely to outside forces is, even under extreme circumstances, a disrespect to other extraordinary human beings.

Overall, while it is clearly absurd to reject that we are under many outside influences, we are simply not, as I argued above, determined by them. In the end, we always make our own call.

95. Although innovations such as video, computers, and the Internet seem to offer schools improved methods for instructing students, these technologies all too often distract from real learning.
ways

When you, as a parent, watch your 12-year-old kid playing GTA in front of the TV for 4 hours when all his schoolwork is still blank, it is easy for you to accuse the game of distracting your boy. The prompt is indeed making a similar accusation, which in my opinion, has overstated the harm that technology has on children while not giving enough credit to the marvelous potential technology can bring to learning.

Let me just list out how technologies are often believed to distract. First, games on computers and smartphones are said to take up too much of children's time. Second, Internet pornography is a threat to children and even adults' lifestyle. Third, social networks force people to spend too much time building meaningless relationships. I do have counterarguments for all of these points. For starters, people need leisure time; children today need games, just like children in the past enjoyed TV programs. As long as the needs are harnessed, they don't necessarily hinder learning. As for pornography I still have just one word, harnessing, so it doesn't have to be bad. Finally, meaningless relationships on Facebook are no more damaging or time consuming than getting intoxicated in a nightclub or bar with a bunch of fake friends. Humanity is to blame, rather than technology.

Having addressed all the concerns, let me redirect to technology's potential contributions to learning, and there are many. First, it's much less confined by time and finances. This is a wonder to people in less advanced areas, because now all they need is a computer connected to the internet to access quality information in any discipline. Wikipedia, Coursera, and Harvard open courses, these are just few among many sources for learning that potentially set people on a level playing field, well, a less uneven playing field at least.

Second, technologies make learning customized, and thus more effective. Interactive apps are designed to recognize learners' personalities, habits, and growth, and to store all this information to adjust future learning curves. Many tech companies are exploiting this possibility, so even though it is still premature as an idea, it is easy to imagine how much it can elevate learning experience in the future. The machine can adjust the pace, the humor, the logic, the interface, and a lot of other factors in ways that make learning more fun and less stressful.

Finally, technology bridges gaps. Learning isn't just about learning hardcore textbook knowledge. It is also about the learning of people and culture. Technologies help people set their eyes on a much expanded universe, where they not just see, but also feel, what it is like to be someone completely different. This potential is especially exciting to me, because it finally makes it possible for our world to be one. When the old earth is filled with parochialism racism and nationalism, technologies offer the opportunity for people to set aside their biases and build bonds across borders. And this, I believe is the most necessary lesson for all.

Overall, my position on this is unequivocal, even though have far from exhausted the advantages that technologies bestow on learning. It is easy for me to see past the trouble that technologies allegedly brought about, and to embrace the bright future they promise.

98. To be an effective leader, a public official must maintain the highest ethical and moral standards.
challenge

Why would an effective leader need to maintain the highest moral standards? That statement may sound absurd in the beginning, but with certain modern developments, an untarnished moral image is probably necessary to maintain effective leadership.

Obviously, there are areas of morality where public officials should never underperform, in the past or now. They should not take bribes. They should not collude with large corporations. They should not sell secrets to enemy nations. These clear rules need no reiteration, and I don't think anyone will openly object. These are not just ethical guidelines; they already step into the legal, realm, for a good reason. Without these regulations, there will be no justice or security.

What is more debatable are the moral rules regarding an official's personal life. Can he/she have an affair? Can he/she openly insult other people? Does it matter if he/she ever smoked pot? I don't think there has to be any necessary relationship between behaving inappropriately in one's private life and being an ineffective leader. Bill Clinton had the Monica Lewinsky scandal, but he was probably one of the few American presidents in recent decades that brought economic prosperity. Have an affair with whoever you want, but be upright when you try to set out a new policy. That could be the "ideal".

But that's not the reality. The reality is, with the scrutiny of the modern media, your every dark secret goes into public attention. If that's not bad enough, the public would ignore all the contributions you have made, but instead focuses on badmouthing your private secrets. In the end, it undercuts your professional efficiency. Even Bill Clinton spent months dealing with his impeachment and that case cost tons of public resources. Some people really believe that leaders should be moral saints. They believe these public figures are role models for their kids, so they should behave properly. Stupid as that rationale sounds, you cannot change that it is how a lot of people think. And as long as they think that, your public image is important if you want to be a successful leader.

I may have made it sound as if all a leader needs is sound moral image rather than high moral standards. Well, yes, if he/she can secretly be scum but appear upright. In fact, isn't that how most leaders are? All a country needs is that the leader effectively carries out policies and maintains a respectable figure. If he/she somehow manages to achieve both while enjoys his/her private life, kudos to him/her. But am not bit interested in how moral he/she is in his/her secret sphere.

100. In most professions and academic fields, imagination is more important than knowledge. ways

The prompt tries to downplay the importance of knowledge in most professions. However, from my standpoint, both imagination and knowledge are valuable assets in almost every field of endeavor. Imagination without knowledge is unguided, while knowledge without imagination is uninspired. It takes the perfect unison between the two to execute a brilliant idea.

Take the arts for example, the field where imagination is certainly the key. When we look at any artist in history who initiated a new trend, there were always fresh new perspectives to observe the world. Picasso was certainly quite imaginative when he took apart objects and reassembled them in unprecedented ways. Van Gogh was certainly brave when he manipulated light and color in a non-traditional method. However, outsiders are often negligent of the fact that both these masters were well trained in their early lives, a training that provided the necessary expertise for their later height. Their examples aptly demonstrate that artistic achievement is often the happy marriage of creative vision and masterful technique.

The same holds for science a field where the importance of knowledge is often stressed. True, it is hard to imagine a Nobel Prize winner in physics who is not familiar with quantum mechanics or general relativity. In this area, solid mathematical skills and understanding of past physical theories are essential in making new discoveries. However, no matter how much data a physicist compiles, it won't automatically be formulated into a new hypothesis It takes imagination, therefore, to come up with new ways to interpret observed phenomena. Simply put, without the support of knowledge a new theory is just an unreliable guess; without imagination, evidence is never more than some meaningless numbers.

The business field is no exception in its reliance on both knowledge and imagination. Any executive in a modern international corporation must be familiar with the supply and demand relationship. He/She also needs to understand the roles and obligations of each position within the company so as to make them collaborate effectively. However, knowledge alone isn't going to produce a new product. Any good product that completely changes consumers' habits, the iPhone, Facebook, or Airbnb, is revolutionary in its own way, which reflects its founders' vision and imagination.

The list doesn't stop here. Whether in the military, in sports, or in politics, the rule is the same. Progress is possible when one dares to imagine what didn't exist before. But progress is realized only when people with knowledge and skills build up the way to what has been imagined.

102. Critical judgment of work in any given field has little value unless it comes from someone who is an expert in that field.

Ways

When a piece of work is produced in a field, who is qualified to critique it? No doubt experts within the field have valid opinions, but who else? In my view, whether a critique from a complete outsider is valuable is a question that depends on the nature of the field, which requires more careful examination.

In rigorous sciences, laymen don't have much to contribute. A few years ago, a folk scientist alleged that he had established the existence of gravitational waves. It became quite a story when a couple of years ago the gravitational wave was finally experimentally proven to exist. Media everywhere spread that folk scientist's old story as if he was some sort of a prophet. Insiders take him as, well, a joke. You can say black holes exist or don't; you can say whether the number of stars in the universe is odd or even; you can also claim that Einstein's theory of relativity is right or wrong. You can say whatever you want, but it doesn't matter, because science doesn't need opinions, but proof based on observation and sound logic. Anything involving flawed reasoning or incomplete data, no matter how correct it turns out, fails to stand as a sound theory. Thus, an outsider, without the necessary training or data, contributes literally nothing to this rigorous practice.

The complete opposite is professional sports. The year 2018 was the year of the Soccer World Cup, the festival for countless "soccer fans" who have only heard the names of two players, Leo Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo. They randomly watched a game and decided to support, say, team Germany, and berated the team for failing to qualify. Or they saw Mbappe, the promising kid from France,dive, and lambasted him for lacking sportsmanship. Or they watched the only game in their life, the finals, and were convinced that the referee held bias against Croatia. Do their opinions matter? These people hardly know a thing about soccer, but ironically, they matter, even more than those fans that have watched the Champions League their entire lives. Being the most influential sport on earth, soccer establishes its dominance not just because of its most loyal fans, but also because of its continual attraction to new fans. The World Cup is carnival for everyone, beginners or experts. The collective celebration, whether rational or impulsive, is what keeps soccer's influence pervasive and persistent.

Even though I've listed only two fields, I believe I've made my point clear. Whether outside opinions matter is related to how much the field places its survival and prosperity on outsiders. If it is a relatively closed circle like science, then peer review is probably all it needs; in contrast, for a field that reciprocates with the general public, it requires the opinions of many.

115. Some people claim that you can tell whether a nation is great by looking at the achievements of its rulers, artists, or scientists. Others argue that the surest indicator of a great nation is, in fact, the general welfare of all its people.
both of the views

How should we define a great nation by its people's general welfare, or instead by the achievements of its elites? To me, both factors are indispensable for a nation to be called "great".
On the one hand, to identify a great nation, one certainly should not miss its people's welfare. There are countless cases in human history in which a nation's outstanding individuals produce many remarkable achievements at the cost of people's livelihood. Such nation can hardly be counted as great, for it misses the original intention of humans to form political entities, namely, to protect the people. These totalitarian nations produce each monumental project to fulfill the personal ambitions and pleasures of the tyrant. One needs to look no further than the former Soviet Union to confirm this point. It made countless scientific achievements within the last century but at the expense of its common people's livelihood. In the end, when many of its people were short of bread and milk, the country could no longer survive on satellites and semiconductors. Whatever achievements were made, they were not dedicated to making its people's life better. When we now look at this history, we think that its atrocities have overshadowed any of its greatness.
On the other hand, even though the general welfare of the people is a necessary indicator of a great nation it is not a sufficient marker. In fact, when we look at the names of great nations in the entirety of human history, these names pop out: ancient Greece, the Roman Empire, China, Great Britain, modern America, and so on. When we think about them, we do not immediately reflect on the comfort of their people, but we remind ourselves of all the marks these countries have imprinted on the entirety of human civilization, such as democracy, the aqueduct, paper, the laws of motion, and free speech, just to name a few. Apparently, these all have much to do with great individuals. In sharp contrast with these examples are the wealthy countries surrounding the Persian Gulf. Perhaps their citizens enjoy very happy lives given their financial status. However, these countries cannot leave their names in the hall of fame simply by exploiting natural oil resources.
All in all, the work of great individuals and the general welfare of people are not in tension as the prompt suggests. In a country where life is relatively easy, people have more opportunities to develop their own strengths, and the success of these individuals will, in turn, benefit the life of the general public. To sum up, only through scrutiny into both aspects can one reliably tell how great a nation really is.